

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

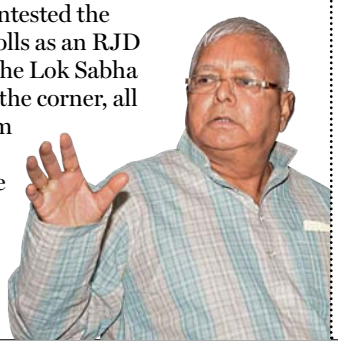
GLASSHOUSE

THE ROVING CMs

With former Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Kiran Kumar Reddy joining the BJP on April 7, the saffron party continues the trend of importing Congress CMs. Last September, it scalped two ex-Congress CMs—Capt. Amarinder Singh in Punjab and Digambar Kamat in Goa. Since Narendra Modi took charge as prime minister in 2014, nine chief ministers from other parties, including seven from the Congress, have joined the BJP. Jharkhand Vikas Morcha (Prajatantrik)'s Babulal Marandi did so in Jharkhand in 2020, the Shiv Sena's Narayan Rane in Maharashtra in 2019, Congressmen S.M. Krishna in Karnataka and Narayan Dutt Tiwari in Uttarakhand in 2017, Vijay Bahuguna in Uttarakhand and Pema Khandu in Arunachal Pradesh in 2016. Four of the BJP's current CMs are also ex-Congressmen, with Khandu being CM in both parties. Four other ex-Congressmen, who formed their own parties, are also CMs.

LALU'S EX-STUDENTS

What do the presidents of the Bihar unit of the BJP, Janata Dal (United) and Congress have in common? All of them have had a past in **Lalu Prasad Yadav**'s Rashtriya Janata Dal. Samrat Choudhary, who took over as state BJP chief on March 27, started his political career in the RJD in 1999. Bihar Congress chief Akhilesh Singh, a minister in the UPA-I government, was in the RJD till 2010. JD(U) Bihar chief Umesh Kushwaha unsuccessfully contested the 2005 assembly polls as an RJD candidate. With the Lok Sabha polls just around the corner, all Bihar parties seem to have pinned their hopes on the men who learned the ropes from the inimitable Lalu.



Vanishing Act



Political and media circles in Maharashtra were agog after reports that the leader of the Opposition **Ajit Pawar** had gone incommunicado on April 7, leaving for an undisclosed location without his security detail. However, the next day, the Nationalist Congress Party leader made a public appearance in Pune and said he had retired for some much-needed rest after his whirlwind tours left him with a prolonged bout of acidity. Despite his entreaties, Pawar, an ex-deputy CM, continues to be the target of media speculation thanks to his short-lived, early-morning dalliance with the BJP in 2019.

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Dhaval Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon and Romita Datta

UPFRONT



Poll Prescription

Trinamool Congress MLA **Nirmal Majhi**, who is also a medical practitioner, has a prescription ready for fellow doctors working under the state government: get them to talk about chief minister Mamata Banerjee and her various social welfare schemes. The state goes to the polls for panchayat in a month or so. With doctors held in high esteem and even viewed as gods, Majhi feels their word might carry weight.

Govt vs the Guv

In an unprecedented move, Tamil Nadu chief minister **M.K. Stalin** on April 10 got the state legislative assembly to suspend a rule, which enabled it to pass a resolution urging the President and the Union government to advise Governor R.N. Ravi to accord his assent to bills adopted by the House in the appropriate time. Soon after, word came from Raj Bhavan that the Governor has signed the bill to ban online gambling that was passed by the assembly a second time in March after the bill originally passed in October 2022 was returned.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR